Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami Maharaj

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A Companion of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta

Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami Maharaj was one of the closest companions of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati and the founder of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math, whose temples and ashrams spread throughout India. His disciples count him the tenth in the line of succession descending from Sri Krishna Chaitanya. His worldly name was Heramba Kumar Bandyopadhyaya; at initiation he became Hayagriva Dasa Brahmachari, and on accepting sannyasa, Parivrajakacharya Tridandi Swami Srimad Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami Maharaj.

One of his biographies was written by his disciple and successor, Srila Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj, who dedicated his book to his “beloved gurudeva” and to his shiksha-guru, Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaj, and first printed its articles in the journal “Sri Chaitanya Vani,” which his guru had founded; that journal also carried, in instalments, the detailed two-volume life of his guru that he wrote in Bengali. The biography opens with Sanskrit pranama-mantras. They glorify Srila Madhava Maharaj as dear to the followers of Sri Rupa, as magnanimity itself; as one who, out of love for his guru and godbrothers, revealed the glory of Ishodyan in Mayapur and restored to the world Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's birthplace in Puri; as the best of the teachers of the Holy Name and a teacher of the whole world.

Appearance and Family

He appeared in 1904, at eight in the morning, on the Utthana Ekadashi of the month of Damodara, in the village of Kanchanpara in Faridpur district, East Bengal.[1] The same lunar day also marks the departure of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji, the guru of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta. Utthana Ekadashi is the day on which Lord Vishnu rises from His yoga-nidra, and his biographer sees a sign in the coincidence: one had come into the world who would awaken suffering souls.

Kanchanpara lies right at the mouth of the Padma, which is called the Kirtinasha there. Upstream is Prema-tali, where Nityananda Prabhu bathed in the river and left prema in its waters for Narottama. Kanchanpara was the home not of his father's family but of his mother's: here lived her brothers, the wealthy Bandyopadhyaya talukdars, who had received from the British the title “Raja-chakravarti,” so that their estate was known as the Chakravarti-bari. Srila Madhava Maharaj's disciples still lovingly call it the home of Gurudeva's uncles.

His father's family lived in the village of Bharakar in Bikrampur, Dhaka district. His grandfather, Chandra Prasad Devasharma Bandyopadhyaya, and his father, Nishikanta, were known as pious men; his mother, Shaibalini Devi, was devoted to the service of the Lord, the brahmanas and the sadhus. His father named the boy Heramba Kumar, but at home he was called Ganesh. He was only four when Nishikanta died; his mother returned to her brothers, and the orphan grew up in Kanchanpara surrounded by his uncles' affection.

Childhood and Schooling

From early childhood he never told a lie, and he taught his friends to be truthful. Worldly amusements held no attraction for him; he loved order and discipline and was always quick to help others, even at his own cost. His mother recalled that whenever he was given a sweet, he would eat it only after sharing it with his friends. Once at school he fell while running and was badly hurt, yet it was he who comforted his frightened teachers: whatever the Lord does is for the best, and for past sins it might have been

worse.

In high school he set up a free library for his poorer classmates. Tall and strong, he was a leader among his peers, captain of the school teams and an actor in its plays; nor did he stand aside from the independence movement, and he read Gandhi's paper “Young India.” But it was his mother who shaped what was deepest in him: she read the scriptures with him, and at her wish he read the “Bhagavad-gita” every day, and by eleven he knew all seven hundred of its verses by heart. He studied in Kanchanpara and Bhatagram, and went to Calcutta for higher education.

The Search for a Guru

In Calcutta he stayed with a kinsman who had been his friend since boyhood, Narayan Chandra Mukhopadhyaya — the same who would later take sannyasa and become Bodhayan Maharaj.[2] Narayan Chandra saw his friend weeping at night as he called out to the Lord; the young man ate once a day, and only havishyanna. Once, in a dream, Narada Muni gave him a mantra and promised that it would bring him to perfection; but on waking he could not recall it in full, and he grieved for a long time.

Resolving to leave home, he went for the blessing of his widowed mother, who was then living in Gosain-Durgapur in Nadia, and with her blessing set out for the Himalayas. Through Hardwar he climbed into the mountains and for three days, without food or water, called upon the Lord. The answer came from above: the guru was not to be sought here — he would appear where you came from. A sadhu in Hardwar told him the same: go back; at home you will meet your true guru.

In Hardwar, by the Brahma-kunda, a wealthy childless merchant couple from North India noticed him. They began urging him to become their adopted son and heir. But he saw in this only a snare of maya, refused, and left for Calcutta. This was around 1925. So, his biographer observes, a heart drawn to the Lord as iron to a magnet can be held back neither by family nor by wealth.

At the Feet of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta

That same year, together with Narayan Chandra and some friends, he first visited Mayapur and saw Srila Bhaktisiddhanta. At a lecture he heard that one must learn to see the Deity — not with eyes blinded by desires, but with eyes of love. That day he witnessed the initiation of Dr. S. N. Ghosh and his wife. Back in Calcutta he began attending hari-katha at the Ultadanga Road math, studied the scriptures and, without telling anyone, gave the math a good deal of money and goods.

In 1927, on the day of Radhashtami, at the Ultadanga Math, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gave him harinama and mantra and named him Hayagriva Dasa Brahmachari; the fire sacrifice was performed by Acharya Dasa Deva Sharma. Soon Hayagriva moved into the math and took the vow of lifelong celibacy, naishthika-brahmacharya. He quickly became one of the leading disciples, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta called his zeal “volcanic energy.” He was among the chief collectors of the donations on which the whole mission depended, including its preaching in the West. He was so close to his guru, and even looked so much like him — tall and fair — that he was often taken for Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's son.

Madras and the South

At his guru's wish he lived for many years — some ten — at the Madras Gaudiya Math. He was responsible for buying the land and building the temple, the natamandira and the living quarters; the temple rose through the labours of Srila Bhakti Rakshak Sridhar Maharaj, Srila Bhakti Hridaya Bon Maharaj, himself and others, and his senior godbrothers always encouraged him. The land was given by Sadashiva Iyer, whose son Ramachandra Iyer advised him to learn Tamil. After three days of lessons a telegram came from Puri: Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said that love for Krishna is not conveyed by language — preach in the languages you know. In Madras he became close to many prominent people.

He was also one of the chief builders of the Ramananda Gaudiya Math, raised in memory of Ramananda Raya: in Andhra, at Goshpada-tirtha, where Ramananda met Mahaprabhu, he bought the land and supervised the construction. He took part in all his guru's undertakings — festivals, parikramas of Vraja and Navadvipa, the opening of maths and pada-pithas, publishing — and was usually sent ahead to prepare the ground. He began nothing without Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's direct instruction; and for this complete surrender, his biographer says, he inherited his guru's power to preach. His fidelity to his guru remains an example to this day. His whole being — thought, meditation, japa — was given to fulfilling his guru's wishes; for an assigned task he would forget food and sleep and labour through the night. And those who met him — a tall, gracious man at home both in modern argument and in the evidence of the shastras — gladly took up whatever he asked of them.

Sarbhog

In March 1936 the Deities of Sri Sri Guru-Gauranga-Gandharvika-Giridhari were to be installed at the Sarbhog Gaudiya Math in Assam, near Barpeta — one of the sixty-four maths of that time. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta sent him ahead with Srila Sridhar Maharaj, Janaki-Vallabha Dasa Brahmachari and others; the math was in the charge of Bhakti Vijnan Ashram Maharaj. With only a few days left before the celebration nothing was ready, and Hayagriva hurriedly arranged lodgings for the guests. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta himself arrived at Sarbhog station on the morning of 15 March with Kunja Bihari Vidyabhushan, Paramananda Vidyaratna, Krishna Keshava Brahmachari and other companions; for three days thousands of people received mahaprasad.

At his guru's instruction Srila Sridhar Maharaj led the installation ceremony; he had dressed and adorned the Deities beforehand. Seeing Them, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta said, “The Deities are already installed,” and Sridhar Maharaj was saddened, thinking he had committed an offence. He asked Hayagriva to write to their guru begging forgiveness on his behalf. The reply came: one who is surrendered commits no offence — the Lord does not see his faults. Srila Madhava Maharaj would often tell this story to his disciples as a lesson in surrender.

At the same time, pressed by Ashram Maharaj, he complained to his guru about a brahmachari named Nimananda. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta was at first angry, then praised him kindly and instructed him: you alone are answerable for the service of the guru, and you should be grateful to anyone who helps — just as Sri Radhika, the “manager” of service to Krishna, is grateful to every helper.

Errands for His Guru

In 1930, during the month-long Janmashtami festival at the Bagbazar Gaudiya Math, the students of the celebrated scientist C. V. Raman asked that he be invited to preside over an evening meeting, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta gave the task to Hayagriva. They spoke in English, in the laboratory on Circular Road. Raman demanded, “Show me God.” Hayagriva answered with an example from Raman's own life: to understand his science one must study under him; so too the truth reveals itself only to one who goes through the process. Raman had no reply, but he declined the invitation.

He and two of his godbrothers were chosen to preach in England; photographs had been taken and passports made. But the rajarshi Sharadindu Narayan Ray advised against sending young and handsome men overseas, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta sent Bhakti Pradip Tirtha in his place, entrusting him instead with raising funds. He was only glad: what he feared most was a long separation from his guru.

In 1936 his guru sent him to Pandit Panchanan Tarkaratna of Bhatpara, who had been attacking daiva-varnashrama. He was told to go with no tilaka and not in Vaishnava clothing, as an ordinary brahmana. In the morning he arrived with Praphulla Chandra Chattopadhyaya of Kanthalpara, found the pandit's son Jiva Nyayatirtha there, and for two hours discussed the scriptures. His conclusion was this:

the pandit's learning is immense, but without the company of a pure devotee no right conclusions are possible. A record of the conversation appeared as the leading article in the Bengali weekly “Gaudiya.” His resourcefulness in such debates, his biographer explains, was the fruit not of book learning but of his guru's grace.

After His Guru's Departure

Departing in 1937, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta charged his disciples to preach the message of Sri Rupa and Raghunatha together. What followed might seem to have gone against that wish, but his biographer sees the will of the Lord even in it: capable disciples, acharyas in their own right, came to preach each on his own, and to revile some while extolling others is an offence against Vaishnavas. In those years he himself went from house to house seeking out disciples who had gone back to family life and brought them back to the math; some of them later became acharyas. He helped any godbrother in trouble — for love of one's godbrothers is the measure of love for one's guru, as love for the devotees is the measure of love for Krishna.

In 1942, together with his godbrothers Srila Bhakti Kumud Santa Maharaj and Srila Bhakti Bichar Jajabar Maharaj, he founded a math in Medinipur and named it after Shyamananda, the first preacher of those parts — the Shyamananda Gaudiya Math. Local men of means helped buy land and a two-storey house in the Shiva-bazar quarter. Among the people of Medinipur was a miser, Govardhan Piri, whom the neighbours advised not even to visit. He would not give the math his family Deities of Radha and Krishna, but he paid for new Deities, ordered from Jaipur, and for Their installation, dress, service and the festival feast; he began to hear hari-katha, gave up his sinful habits and accepted initiation, and his wife thanked Gurudeva for giving her husband back to her. A sadhu does not fear being insulted, Srila Madhava Maharaj used to say; the fruit of preaching is that the wicked become good.

Later he also told his disciples of meeting Vamshidasa Babaji in Medinipur. The Babaji was passing through with pilgrims and promised to visit the Shyamananda Gaudiya Math, but stopped under a pipal tree, taking it for the Vamshi-vata. So Gurudeva went to him himself, and the Babaji, out of love for Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, treated him to sweet rice — “very tasty.”

Sannyasa

Before his sannyasa he preached in the districts of Bankura and Medinipur — at Kether-Danga, Onda, Jhanti-Pahari, Bankura and Gardevata; with him were Krishna Keshava Brahmachari, Rama Govinda Brahmachari, Kunjalal, Hari Govinda and others, and they were helped by Radha Govinda Sit of Kether-Danga and Avinash Pal of Onda.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta had meant to give him sannyasa but did not: the mission needed his gift for collecting too much. After their guru's departure his godbrothers — Kunja Bihari Vidyabhushan, Bhakti Prakash Aranya, Bhakti Sarvasva Giri, Bhakti Svarupa Parvat, Bhakti Prasun Bodhayan Maharajas, Krishna Keshava and Sundar Gopal Brahmacharis — persuaded him to accept sannyasa so as to fulfil their guru's wish. In 1944, on Phalguna Purnima — the day of Mahaprabhu's appearance — on the grounds of the Tota-Gopinatha temple in Puri, he accepted sannyasa from Srila Bhakti Gaurava Vaikhanasa Maharaj; he was about forty years old.[3] Present were Kunja Bihari Vidyabhushan, Paramananda Vidyaratna, Parvat Maharaj and Bodhayan Maharaj. From then on he was called Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami. When he returned to the Shyamananda Gaudiya Math, the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha received him with honour and presented him with an address praising his fearlessness, the power of his words and his love for the devotees.

East Pakistan

After sannyasa, before and after 1947, he travelled long on preaching tours through India and East Pakistan. With him went Mihir, Sankarshan, Krishna Keshava Brahmachari, Trailokya, Mahendra, Sri Brahma, Pyari Mohan Brahmachari, Yajneshvar Dasa Babaji and others; in the districts of Dhaka and Mymensingh they visited Baliati, Nawabganj, Kalakopa, Jamuki, Pakulla and Churain.

At Jamuki-Pakulla he lectured in a pandal by the school before a thousand Hindus and Muslims. The police warned him that a word against Pakistan could land him in prison. Wary of impure prison food, he asked that questions be held until the end. Still a mullah asked him about “idol worship.” Srila Madhava Maharaj replied that God is all-powerful: could the Almighty, he asked, pass an elephant through the eye of a needle? The Lord is He who is able to do, not to do, and to do otherwise; and so He can appear in whatever form He wills. An idol is a product of the mind and of hands working with matter; the sri-vigraha is the form the Lord Himself accepts out of love for His devotee. It is wholly spiritual and is seen only by the eyes of bhakti.

Assam

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta had once told him directly to preach in Assam: the Assamese are simple-hearted and trust sadhus. And so he went there — to Sarbhog, with Bhuvana, Uddharan and Krishna Keshava Brahmachari.[4] Because of the troubles within the Gaudiya Math he stayed not at the math but in the house of Krishna Keshava's brother. There was a flood; they lived on a bamboo platform, and Krishna Keshava's mother cooked for the Vaishnavas. The war with Japan was on; the house was requisitioned for troops, and Maharaj moved to a village near Sarbhog, where he preached for seven days, and afterwards stayed with Gopal Prabhu in Sarbhog itself. So, his biographer remarks, he was ready to bear any hardship to carry out his guru's will and bring good to souls forgetful of Krishna.

In Sarbhog he spoke on the “Bhagavata” daily in the house of the schoolteacher Chinta Haran Patgiri, and his first disciples there were Gopal Dasa Adhikari and his wife, Shivananda Dasa Adhikari, Khagen Dasa Adhikari and Achyutananda Dasa Adhikari. A brahmana youth, Kamala Kanta Goswami, followed him to Bhavanipur-Tapu; his father, Ghana Kanta, took him home, believing he had lost caste by eating the Vaishnavas' food, but the young man came back, though his initiation had to be postponed because of his family. The Marwari merchants of Tapu served the Vaishnavas, and Shivananda gave his son Lokesh to the service. Harinama was received in the house of Tularama Babu in Tapu by Lohita and Lokesh, then by Kamala Kanta, Ram Prasad and Bhavananda; and full initiation in Medinipur was accepted by Lalita Charan, Lokanath and Krishna Prasad Brahmachari — later the sannyasis Bhakti Lalita Giri, Bhakti Suhrid Damodar and Bhakti Prasad Ashram Maharajas.

In Gauhati, thanks to Krishna Keshava and Chinta Haran, he met prominent people — the Chief Minister of Assam, Gopinath Bardoloi, Durgeshvar Sharma, Kumudeshvar Goswami and others — and spoke on the “Bhagavata” in the Chief Minister's house. Bardoloi likened his preaching to Gandhi's “Ram-dhun.” Maharaj reminded him that Gandhi, as he had read in “Young India,” once said he was ready to sacrifice the Ram-dhun for the country — “but we are ready to sacrifice the country for the Ram-dhun.” The Absolute is a Person, and everything exists for Him. Bardoloi wished to leave politics and live in the math, but his colleagues would not let him go, and soon afterwards he died.

He preached also at Bijani, Bhatipara, Hauli and Barpeta. At Hauli, before a gathering of many thousands, a maulvi asked whether anyone had ever seen the soul or God. Maharaj answered with the example of a book in Urdu: one who does not know the language cannot read even its title — but does it follow that it has none? There are two kinds of sight, the sensory and the Vedic, veda-drik; the truth reveals itself to one who surrenders. There Rameshvar Varman took shelter, becoming Rameshvar Dasa Adhikari. In 1945 he walked from Hauli to Barpeta with Krishna Keshava, Gopal Krishna Dasa Adhikari, Trailokyanath, Madhavananda Vrajabasi and Bhuvana Mohan Dasa Adhikari. In Barpeta he

stayed with Amiya Kanti Dasa and Hare Krishna Dasa, who received initiation as Aghadaman Dasa and Hari Dasa. He was honoured too by the satradhikari of Shankaradeva's school, Narayan Deva Mishra, who served as priest at a large gathering in Barpeta and invited Maharaj to his home.

Jiveshvar Goswami of Tihun had grown cold towards the Gaudiya Math after the harsh preaching of a certain householder; having heard Srila Madhava Maharaj, he admitted that he said exactly the same, but in a way that did not wound.

In 1947 he came again to Assam, to Goalpara, at the invitation of Radha Mohan Dasa Adhikari — a householder, a disciple of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta and a former brahmachari, known in Goalpara as “Ram Mohan-da.” With him were Krishna Keshava, Uddharan Brahmachari, Madhavananda Vrajabasi and Ratharudha Dasa Brahmachari. The Harisabha meeting was chaired by the advocate Khiroda Sen; also present were the district attorney Kamakhya Charan Sen and Priya Kumar Guha-Ray, the Mechpara estate's pleader.

In Radha Mohan's house he was first seen by Kamakhya Charan Guha-Ray, son of Dhirendra Guha-Ray, who had come with his friend Devavrata; later he became Krishna Vallabha Brahmachari, and after sannyasa, Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha Maharaj. As he bowed at Maharaj's feet, the young man felt his blessing so strongly that his hair stood on end. He asked: would he lose his family if he chanted the Name? Maharaj answered with the parable of the geese and the swan from Lake Manasa-sarovara: one attached to what is low cannot fly to the Lord. And he cited the “Bhagavata”: “The wise will leave bad company and cling to the saints, whose words cut the knots of the mind's attachments” (SB 11.26.26).

Kamakhya's vartma-pradarshaka-guru — the one who first showed him the path — was Radha Mohan, and it was to his address that Gurudeva's letters came. Maharaj advised the young man to read Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura's “Jaiva-dharma” and wrote that on the path of renunciation, nivritti, government service is not needed, while on the path of pravritti one may take it. Kamakhya resolved to leave home. That same year, 1947, he completed his master's degree in philosophy at Calcutta University and from then on devoted himself wholly to serving his guru; in time he became secretary of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math, one of Maharaj's first sannyasi disciples (taking sannyasa in 1961), and after his departure his successor-acharya.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta had once visited Goalpara and told the householder Nimananda to found a math on Hulukanda Hill by the Brahmaputra — the Prapannashram; it was later lost. When Sharat Kumar Nath offered a house and land, Srila Madhava Maharaj saw in this the fulfilment of his guru's wish and in 1969 opened a branch of the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math there.

Almost every year he returned to Assam with disciples and godbrothers, travelling on foot and by bullock cart, and hundreds became his disciples. He preached in the districts of Goalpara (Dhubri, Basugaon, Bilasipara), Kamrup and Barpeta (Gauhati, Sarbhog, Chakchaka-bazar, Pathshala, Rangia, Nalbari, Amingaon), Darrang (Tezpur, Mangaldai), Cachar (Silchar, Hailakandi), Sibsagar and Lakhimpur, and also in Shillong. The surrendered have nothing to fear, his biographer says: their selfless service cannot be stopped. As the “Bhagavata” says: “Your devotees, O Madhava, bound to You by ties of love, never fall from the path; protected by You, O Lord, they stride fearlessly over the heads of the enemy's commanders” (SB 10.2.33). In Assam he opened maths in Tezpur, Gauhati and Goalpara.[5]

The Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math

He left the Sri Chaitanya Math when already mature in years; in his biographer's words, Mahaprabhu Himself led him out of a constricted position — and in a short time he built large centres all over India. No efforts of the envious can hide a true guru, just as a passing cloud cannot veil the sun, and to oppose

him is an offence against a Vaishnava. In a difficult time his “right and left hands” in managing the temples were two Calcuttans, Manikantha Mukhopadhyaya and Dr. S. N. Ghosh, head of the Homeopathic Factory — the same whose initiation he had witnessed in Mayapur in 1925; later the advocate Jayanta Kumar Mukhopadhyaya took on much of the management.

He preached in the Punjab and in Hyderabad, those strongholds of mayavada, and hundreds there accepted Mahaprabhu's teaching. Atul Krishna Goswami of the Radha-Ramana temple in Vrindavana called him a peerless spiritual giant. At his inspiration many educated and influential men accepted tridandi-sannyasa. Warm, tolerant and forbearing, he drew people of every station — and that, says his biographer, is why the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math grew so quickly.

He obtained the land and houses at Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's birthplace in Puri. The house on Grand Road near Narayan-chata where his guru was born stood on the property of the Dakshina-parshva Math; in 1974 Srila Madhava Maharaj recovered it, and today a Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math with a temple stands there. He was also the chief organiser of the all-India celebration of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's centenary, in which all his godbrothers took part.

In Jashra, in Nadia, the Deities of Jagadisha Pandita — Lord Jagannatha and Gaura-Gopala — entrusted Themselves to his service. Jagadisha's descendants, Vishvanath Goswami and Shambhunath and Mrityunjaya Mukhopadhyaya, could no longer maintain the worship or the crumbling temple; on the advice of Panchu Thakura of Jashra and Santosh Kumar Mallik of Ranaghat they handed the temple over to him unconditionally. The account of it printed in “Sri Chaitanya Vani,” which his biographer reproduces, compares this to Gopala waiting for Madhavendra Puri: the Deities Themselves offered Themselves to the one who would serve Them. Maharaj repaired the temple, brought in electricity, built a guesthouse for pilgrims, and in the first year personally seated and fed several thousand people with mahaprasad.

The maths and ashrams he founded are listed in the biography year by year. The first was the Shyamananda Gaudiya Math in Medinipur (1942); then came maths in Tezpur (1948) and Gauhati (1953), in Calcutta on Rash Behari Avenue (1955), and the main math at Ishodyan in Sri Mayapur (1956). In Vrindavana there arose the Sarveshvar-haveli (1956), a math on Mathura Road (1960) and the Sri Vinoda-vani Gaudiya Math at Kaliya-daha (1967); in Krishnanagar, a math at Goari-bazar (1960); in Calcutta, the math on Satish Mukherjee Road (1961; the new temple opened in 1967). In Mathura-mandala came the Sri Gaudiya Sevashram at Madhuvana (1961) and an ashram at Gokula-Mahavan (1975); in Hyderabad, two maths (1962 and 1972); in Jashra, the shripat of Jagadisha Pandita (1962). These were followed by Goalpara (1969), Chandigarh (1970),[6] Puri (1974), the Jagannatha temple in Agartala (1976) and Dehradun (1977). In 1955 two more maths passed into his care — in Sarbhog, and the Sri Gadai-Gauranga Math in Baliati.

He also opened schools: a chatushpathi in Medinipur (1946), a primary school and a Sanskrit vidyapitha at Ishodyan (1959), the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Vidyamandir, a school of Western languages and a Sanskrit college in Calcutta (1961–1968), and a Sanskrit school and a school of Indian languages in Chandigarh (1972); libraries in Calcutta (of comparative religion) and in Chandigarh; and free dispensaries at Ishodyan, Chandigarh and Puri. In 1961 he founded the monthly “Sri Chaitanya Vani,” and in 1964 the Sri Chaitanya Vani Press. That same year, 1964, he invited Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaj to head the journal's editorial board, where he served for thirty-three years; earlier still, after Puri Maharaj's sannyasa in 1946, the two of them, with Bon Maharaj, had travelled across India.

He told his disciples that it would be enough to translate Srila Bhaktivinoda Thakura's books into the languages of the world. And Srila Sridhar Maharaj he regarded as his shiksha-guru, as did many other disciples of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta — Bhaktivedanta Swami, Bhakti Prajnana Keshava, Bhakti Saranga

Goswami, Bhakti Pramoda Puri.

A Talk on Guru-puja Day

In 1967 his disciples celebrated his appearance day, Utthana Ekadashi — also the departure day of Srila Gaurakishora Dasa Babaji — at the Calcutta temple on Satish Mukherjee Road. In the evening Maharaj spoke to them and, among other things, recalled what “revered Puri Maharaj” had told of the Babaji.

He had, he said, three gurus: the Lord, who dispels ignorance; Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, who drew him into service; and all the Vaishnavas, his own disciples included. Guru and disciple are to each other both the object of service and the one cared for — as Yashoda, for whom Gopala was the object of her service, bound Him as her own child. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta addressed all his disciples as “prabhu” and with the respectful “apni,” using the familiar “tumi” with only a few — yet he instructed them and corrected them sternly.

Whoever honours him, Maharaj said, in truth honours his guru. In his guru he had seen nothing but the desire to please the Lord; otherwise his guru would not have kept him in the math. Without love for the guru, for Krishna and Radha, renunciation is false; true renunciation is yukta-vairagya, offering everything in service. He cited the “Upadeshamrita”: one who has mastered the urges of speech, mind, anger, tongue, belly and genitals can instruct the whole world; the “Gita”: the taste for sense objects leaves only when the Supreme is seen (BG 2.59); and the “Bhagavata”: by whatever means, fix the mind on Krishna (SB 7.1.32) — which is attained through the association of saintly devotees (SB 7.7.30).

Last Instructions

In 1976 he registered the Sri Chaitanya Gaudiya Math as a society under West Bengal law. In December of that year he signed a letter — “Tridandi-bhikshu Sri Bhakti Dayita Madhava”: his health was failing; all the maths were registered; they were governed by twelve trustees, removable only for grave misconduct; as president and acharya after himself he appointed Tridandi Swami Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha.

On the morning of 30 December 1978, at the Calcutta math, at Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha's request and against his doctor's orders not to talk much, he gave instructions to a Western devotee from Chandigarh. Devotion must be exclusive, given to Krishna alone, as a faithful wife is devoted to her husband; the demigods are not to be reviled, but neither are they to be set on a par with Krishna: “krishnas tu bhagavan svayam” — Krishna is Bhagavan Himself (SB 1.3.28). The “Chaitanya-charitamrita” says the same: “Only the original Lord of all that exists, the source of all Avataras and manifestations of God, is worthy to be called Svayam Bhagavan” (CC, Adi 2.88).

He spoke too of succession. The math is no one's property; there is one acharya, and he is also the president. The acharya is not elected by vote — he is indicated by the Lord, from above; so it is in all four sampradayas. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, he recalled, rejected a constitution with an elective procedure drawn up by the advocate J. N. Basu — he himself and two or three others were present. Having consulted his senior godbrothers, he appointed Bhakti Ballabha Tirtha as his successor and president. No one should be expelled from a math for quarrelling, but reasoned with; if that fails, give him money and a letter and transfer him to another math; and obey the appointed head.

Three obstacles stand on the path: money, women and the thirst for fame; that is why Srila Bhaktisiddhanta sang that a Vaishnava is one who has given up gold, women and prestige. What is collected in a day must be handed to the math that same day; the sick must be treated, even on credit — he himself had once secretly borrowed money for provisions, and only Uddharan knew; a householder,

Govinda Babu, helped then. He recalled collecting together with “Sripad Goswami Maharaj” and Sripad Nemi Maharaj, while Bhakti Pradip Tirtha, Jajabar Maharaj and Sridhar Maharaj went with him; he never spent temple money on himself and asked “Kunja-da” only for the cloth he needed. And fame, when fled from, follows love for Krishna of itself: “Fearing universal honour, Sri Madhavendra Puri left Remuna. But fame followed him, born of his pure love for Krishna” (CC, Madhya 4.147). So in his last instructions he once more said what mattered most: the acharya is appointed from above, devotion belongs to Krishna alone, and money, women and fame are the three hindrances.

Tirtha Maharaj, he said, cannot always be here — let Jagamohan Prabhu manage the math. He asked forgiveness if he had been harsh, and closed with obeisance to the Vaishnavas: “I bow to the Vaishnavas — wish-fulfilling trees, oceans of mercy, deliverers of the fallen.”

Departure and Samadhi

Srila Bhakti Dayita Madhava Goswami Maharaj left this world in 1979, on the Gaura-pratipad of the month of Govinda, at nine in the morning, while the Holy Names were being sung, in his own room in the Calcutta math, Satish Mukherjee Road; in his biographer's words, he entered the Lord's eternal pastimes at the hour of His morning pastimes with Sri Radha. The departures of Srila Jagannatha Dasa Babaji and of Rasikananda Deva Gosvami are commemorated on the same day.[7]

At four that afternoon his body was carried to Mayapur with kirtan and laid in samadhi according to the scriptures; the rites were performed by Srila Bhakti Pramoda Puri Maharaj. Two days later a memorial festival was held at the main math in Ishodyan, and on 22 March many of his godbrothers gathered in the sankirtana hall of the Calcutta math; the meeting was led by Srila Bhakti Hridaya Bon Maharaj, and the guest of honour was Tushar Kanti Ghosh, publisher of the “Amrita Bazar Patrika.”

1. According to one biography — on Friday, 3 Agrahayana of the Bengali year 1311 (18 November 1904), in the village of Kanchanpara, Madaripur subdivision, Bhedarganj thana. The day agrees with our calendar.

2. So one biography states: “took sannyasa from him.” Yet the same biographer names Bhakti Prasun Bodhayan Maharaj among the godbrothers who persuaded Srila Madhava Maharaj to accept sannyasa and were present at it in 1944; so Bodhayan Maharaj must have taken sannyasa earlier, and not from him — probably an inexactness of the account.

3. The biography says “at forty” and “on the 457th anniversary of Mahaprabhu's appearance.” But with his appearance in November 1904, in March 1944 he was in his fortieth year (thirty-nine full years), and Gaura Purnima 1944 was the 458th anniversary of the Lord's appearance (1486); the biography's count seems to be a year off.

4. The biography places this journey after the preaching in East Pakistan (around 1947), yet says in the same breath that the war with Japan was on, that is, before 1945; and the walk from Hauli to Barpeta is dated 1945. Most likely his first journeys to Assam fell in the war years.

5. The list of institutions appended to the biography names more Assamese maths: Tezpur (1948), Gauhati (1953) and Goalpara (1969), and besides these the Sarbhog Gaudiya Math, which passed into his care in 1955.

6. In the list of institutions the Chandigarh math is in Sector 20-A, but in the account of his works and in the lists of schools, libraries and dispensaries, in Sector 20-B.

7. According to the biography — on Tuesday, 14 Phalguna of the Bengali year 1386 (so the biography; February 1979 fell in the Bengali year 1385) — 27 February 1979, “Govinda 26, year 492 of the Chaitanya era.” The figure “Govinda 26” does not agree with the Gaura-pratipad (the new moon fell the day before) — probably a different count of the month's days; the day of departure is given by our calendar.